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Dick Hyman

The term "Renaissance Man" most certainly applies to pianist Dick Hyman. Highlights in his recording career include "The Complete Works of Scott Joplin," "Seven Ages of Jazz," numerous trio albums and one of the first synthesizer-based recordings. His arrangements have found a home with Count Basie, Doc Severinsen, The Mills Brothers and Al Hirt, and he is well known for his film scoring for Woody Allen. Born in New York City on March 3, 1927, he eventually found himself playing behind some of the greatest jazz stars, including Charlie Parker, Lester Young and Benny Goodman. Currently, Dick divides his time between his own group, The New York Jazz Repertory, and performing at numerous festivals and jazz parties.

Dick was interviewed by Monk Rowe on March 4, 1995 in Scottsdale, Arizona.

MR: We are here today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and we have the great pleasure of talking with Mr. Dick Hyman, who has been described in a number of ways: eclectic, versatile, a Renaissance Man, and, I want to see if we can figure out when all that started and perhaps we'll discuss why he's called all those things. Do you think being born in New York City was important for your early —

DH: For my being a Renaissance Man? Well, the fact that I was in New York did permit me to see a lot of people live when I was in my teens, and there was so much going on and there was still activity on 52nd street and in Greenwich Village. It was something that I guess people who grow up in Peoria don't have. And then the fact also that I was able to get into studio work not too long after I began playing professionally, that was another thing that might not have happened to people who weren't as fortunate as to be around New York.

MR: Yeah. In your early career, you were, when we listen to you play, we can tell that you had some classical training.

DH: Yeah. I studied with an uncle of mine, other teachers too, but finally I was proficient enough to study with an uncle of mine who was a concert pianist. His names was Anton Rovinsky. And I learned a lot of things from him. I'm still learning from him actually, in a sense.

MR: But to do studio work like that it's obvious that you had to be able to sight read and do things in a short time.

DH: Well see a lot of us began playing jazz and then got into studio work, and were able to use some of that jazz expertise in one way or another in studio work. The improvisation for a pianist always came in very handy. And then the studio work taught us a lot of other things like in my case I began to play organ as well as to read and learn how to arrange

and conduct and so forth. And then the funny thing is, and when I use the plural I mean people like not only myself but people like Milt Hinton and Bob Rosengarden and I'm thinking of present company and certain other guys. The funny thing is that after a while the studio work came to an end and we all became entirely jazz people after that, again. So it was a kind of hiatus that might have lasted decades but it was a kind of a wonderful hiatus.

MR: I understand you studied some with Teddy Wilson early on.

DH: Yeah I did. I won a contest, a local radio station had a contest and the prize was twelve lessons with Teddy Wilson. So I did do that, and it was wonderful. I continued to be friends with him until he passed away a few years ago.

MR: What was it like playing with some of the jazz legends? I mean is there one or two people that stood out in your mind from all the people you've played with over the years. I know you've played with Dizzy, and —

DH: Well Benny Goodman certainly. Back in 1950, I got tapped to play with his sextet on a European tour. I was 23. And now that I think of it, Benny wasn't any more than in his 40's at that time, and we thought of him as the grand old man.

MR: He'd already had his whole swing thing.

DH: Yeah. We went to Europe with a group that included Zoot Sims and Roy Eldridge and Toots Thielemans joined us. He wasn't yet an American, he was still living in Belgium. Charlie Short, the English bass player, the singer Nancy Reed, who am I leaving out? That's about it. It was a wonderful thing. Some of those performances were recorded, too, I have tapes of some of them that were recorded for a radio program in Sweden and one or two others I guess that were somewhere else on the tour. We played Sweden and Switzerland, Italy, France.

MR: Did you notice a difference in playing over there? Because a number of people have talked about the difference in the way the music is accepted, or the artists, between the United States and Europe.

DH: Well at that time it was quite noticeable. I'm not sure you could say — I think you could say it's the same now. Europeans came to appreciate jazz as an art form earlier than, ironically, earlier than we did in America. They got into it in a scholarly way, and a critical way, earlier than anybody else did, with the exception of people like Leonard Feather perhaps. But even in the 20's, the French were into jazz and Charles Delaunay was the first person to think of doing a discography of jazz recordings. That was in the early 30's if I'm not mistaken.

MR: It seems like sometimes the — something that comes from somewhere else has an exotic quality to it.

DH: Oh yeah.

MR: Just like we might listen to Russian folk music and think it's really really artsy, where they think of it as everyday music.

DH: That's very true. I think the Europeans have always wanted to hear jazz in concert more or earlier than we ever did here. Of course another change that we've all witnesses is that now in general jazz is heard in concert, there are still jazz clubs, but there are many more jazz concerts. So that's another strange twist of events.

MR: Is there a part of your career that you enjoy more than others? I mean you've done so many things it's almost like you have to have an assistant to carry your hats, because you've written for films, and you've played with many many jazz artists, and made your own records, and I'm interested to see if all of this has come about of your own curiosity or has some of it happened serendipitously, or because of things like making a living?

DH: Well, I learned early on that the more things I could do, the more I'd be called to work, and making a living is a very big factor for all of us. So I was pleased to learn organ and be on call for all kinds of peculiar, non-jazz organ things, and played piano in very odd situations indeed, and arranging began to come around because I was so active every other way so I began to be the arranger and conductor on dates. But you've asked whether, what I really liked to do. And I think that early on and finally in a sense, what I really like to do is play solo piano, solo jazz piano. That's really the way I began and it's probably the way I'll end up too. I think I can express myself best doing that. And as much as I love playing with rhythm sections and with great people like Milt, the solo piano thing ties in with my earliest piano training. So it's what I continue working on full time.

MR: I believe one of your most recent recordings was a Gershwin collection? I'm curious as to, from a technical standpoint, what have you found was one of your most challenging prospects? Because when you record Scott Joplin, this is music that's pretty much written out, yet it has to be played like it doesn't sound like it's written.

DH: I think that all piano music, not just jazz, not just Scott Joplin, but classical music in general, it should sound as though the performer is improvising it. That's what I think. And at its best, in my judgment, I can convince myself in an irrational way, that that is happening. And if you hear Mozart played that way, it sounds like the performer might be improvising it. We know they're not. But there are aspects of performance that even people who are playing note for note understand. And it has to sound as though it's happening at that moment.

MR: How about your arranging career? What was some of your first experiences in arranging and was it difficult for you at that time, and did you learn this craft from someone else or was it kind of trial and error?

DH: Well I studied orchestration for a while, legitimate orchestration, in Juilliard, but really whatever I've learned has come about from being there. And I used to play with so many kinds of orchestras that it was bound to rub off. And in any case, a pianist is always arranging, because half of what you get to play, even to play in a non-jazz situation is shorthand, and the figured bass really, and you have to be making up and filling in and amplifying what the rest of the orchestra is doing or not doing what the rest of the orchestra is doing. You just have to have some arranging skills simply to play piano in an orchestra. So I began to arrange, as the situations came up. It was very hard at first, because it was so much easier to play, but you have to accept the prospect of delayed gratification. And that's still the case with arranging. You'll kill yourself and stay up all night, and then you wonder if it's worth it. But it is when you hear it played back.

MR: Have you ever had to arrange for a musical group where the players were not good readers?

DH: Yeah.

MR: How do you deal with that situation?

DH: With patience.

MR: Do you purposely write easy things? I mean —

DH: Well there is such a thing as writing minimal things for people perhaps who are not good readers but who are great improvisers. You don't write out much for them, you just try to get them to do what they do so wonderfully. Sometimes, then there's the kind of orchestration if you were writing for a high school band, for example, you don't write in real complicated things. There are things to be done. And occasionally you run into situations you've misjudged and you just have to take your time and not get upset and not make a person who is not as good a reader as everybody else is, not make him feel embarrassed because then he'll do an even worse job. You just have to work it out, maybe help him a little bit. All of this is kind of basic psychology.

MR: When you wrote for the Basie band, were there particular soloists at that time that you kept in mind?

DH: Well the things I did for Basie, if I can remember, were as it happened, I think Teddy Reig had a notion that I could write for singers with the Basie band. I think the first thing I did was something or other for a television show, and I don't remember who the singer was, and on the strength of that I began to do other things for the Basie band in a similar way. I did an album for Arthur Prysock and I remember that Prysock's key turned out to be E major, an unusual one.

MR: Ooh. Bad one for bands.

DH: Well it's okay really, the band didn't have a problem, but Basie did. As soon as he saw the signature he said "you play it." Which I did.

MR: No kidding?

DH: Yeah.

MR: What was his key?

DH: Well his key was F I'd say.

MR: Yeah? From "One o'clock Jump" right?

DH: Yeah. Then some time went by and I did some other things which I think were more successful. The Mills Brothers album, "Chairman of the Board," and was there as second one, I can't quite remember whether I did one or maybe two of them. But that was really great because that was taking things that the Mills Brothers and Basie had done and just making them fit together. And I enjoyed that. And I also did an album with Basie for Kay Starr, who was a surprisingly hip singer and it was a surprisingly good album. I must say I had a sense of what am I doing here when I'd get up there and be conducting the Basie band. The one thing I would never do would be to beat off the tempo. I'd insist that Basie did that. Basie was so easy going that he'd just as soon turn over the whole thing to somebody and let somebody do it and not be bothered. He was a very nice man.

MR: Some of our younger viewers might not remember the Arthur Godfrey Show, but did you have some experiences in there that were new? It must have been that every week something would come along.

DH: It was a daily show and additional — a daily radio show — and additional occasional television shows. Well I really was in a position to be forced to learn very quickly quite a number of things. I had to make sure my conducting was up to standards, because many of those things were not just beating off tempo, they were conducting music comedy or even light opera kind of material. And it was a peculiar band. I acquired the band you might say, and it already included Lee Irwin on organ, and Lud Flato on piano. So we turned it into a three keyboard band. I played perhaps more Hammond organ than piano in that show. The fellow who had been there, Lee Irwin, he played Allen organ and we divided up the functions. And Flato, on piano, was very useful playing a Trylvestan keyboard glockenspiel if I was busy doing something else. So that worked out fine.

MR: Were you responsible for sound effects, anything like that?

DH: No we didn't do that. No the strange thing about that show was that Godfrey had fallen in love with jazz. And we turned it into a jazz band. Sometimes it was a Dixieland band and Godfrey would play along with his ukulele, and he was very cooperative in wanting to learn the correct chords. And at other times he would give us free reign and we did everything from Charlie Mingus to whatever was happening back then, back then being 1959, 1960. We played amazingly hip things for the Arthur Godfrey Show. "Bags' Groove," Charlie Mingus, "This Here, Dat Dere," Bobby Timmons, things like that. We got away with murder, frankly. Everybody seemed to like it.

MR: And it was live too, right?

DH: Not always. After a while we would tape, then we'd tape maybe two shows a day and then have the rest of the week off, that kind of thing.

MR: Can you tell me something about some of the records you made for MGM? They had some interesting titles.

DH: MGM was a company that I've recorded for that wanted me to play like a particular recording that was beginning to be popular in France I remember. And it involved a harpsichord piano, that is a grand piano with staples in the hammers so it gave it a clangy sound. It's useful actually for a harpsichord, even legitimate harpsichord pieces because it's much louder than a regular harpsichord. At any rate, that was the sound, and it was a very peculiar, not to say moronic treatment that was required. And that's how I got a contract with MGM. After a while that kind of music and a couple of albums that I'd rather not hear anymore, ran their course and I began to play better for them.

MR: What about the, I noticed that you've also done some early work with synthesizers when they came out.

DH: I really did.

MR: Were they quite a bit larger than they are now I would imagine?

DH: Well it rather looked like an old fashioned telephone switchboard. Because you really did put cables from one hole into another hole, and the whole thing was a complicated style of cables. I guess I was the first guy to do pop and/or jazz at least jazz flavored things, on the synthesizer. And it followed shortly after the synthesizer had been introduced, really, to recording by "Switched On Bach." That was — of course, I can't say that I mastered the synthesizer by any means. I was working with Walter Carlos, not Walter Carlos, Walter Sear. Carlos of course was the other person. Seer had been an associate in turn with Moog himself, who invented the Moog synthesizer. And we were able to work out various things that created, I guess, it was the first pop synthesizer record. After a time, I kind of bowed out of that field. There are many synthesists who came along who really specialized in it, and knew what they were doing far better than I did. And besides, ragtime and stride piano came back, and I was much more interested in doing that.

MR: Well I've noticed that one thing that we've been interested in here in doing these archival tapes is that we keep some of the earlier jazz stories and music alive for students and anyone watching. And it seems to be kind of a passion of yours that the early, some of the early keyboard styles. Is this something that you've liked from the beginning? Or did you come to it later on?

DH: I liked it from the beginning, and the beginning for me really was a large collection of 78 RPM records which my big brother had collected and left to me when he went off to college. That really was my basic education. The records included stuff by Jelly Roll

Morton, stuff by Fats Waller and Teddy Wilson. And although I didn't like it much at first, even stuff by Zez Confrey and ragtime people like that, novelty piano people like that. But I never thought that I would be using that background in my professional career. It never seemed that there was any reason to expect that. But at a certain point it did happen and I brushed off what I remembered from all that and got involved in Scott Joplin specifically and Jelly Roll Morton and it came in very handy. And I really do like all that stuff now. It's kind of part of me.

MR: Do you listen to music as much as let's say, a non-musician who loves music? Do you spend a lot of time listening to music still?

DH: Yes. I do listen to a lot of music.

MR: Sometimes musicians themselves seem to maybe not listen as much because it's like their job every day.

DH: Well, yeah, no I like to listen to — I don't necessarily listen to a great deal of jazz, although a fair amount of that, but I like to listen to classical music. We have a local public radio station in Florida that does a wide variety of stuff. But if I have my own inclination, tapes I might put in the car to play, it might be Richard Strauss in particular.

MR: You have some wide tastes.

DH: Strauss was wonderful. He went absolutely as far as you can go without jettisoning the whole idea of tonality.

MR: I'd like to maybe turn back the clock a little bit again. I'm interested in your playing with people like Dizzy and Charlie Parker and the 52nd Street scene. Is this something you can describe to us — what that was like back then?

DH: Well you know that famous film of Charlie Parker that I'm on just happened. I was playing a New York local daily television show with a bass player and we would accompany any singers that came on to the show. And one day it appeared that Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie would be awarded an *Esquire* Magazine award by Leonard Feather.

MR: What year was this?

DH: 1952. So we added a drummer to the duo, who was Charlie Smith, and the bass player was a sub that day actually, he was Sandy Block. And sure enough, Bird and Dizzy came on the show and they did "Hot House" and that turned out to be the only sound film that exists of Charlie Parker. And it's also a very young Dizzy at that point if you look, if you see him. I worked a little bit with Dizzy later on in one thing or another and I remember that Bird came and sat in with us at Tony Scott's combo at Cafe Society and I think that recording is also bootlegged and out somewhere.

MR: Most of them are, one way or another.

DH: Huh?

MR: Most of them are somehow. Do you remember what was it like to play behind him? At that time was it like kind of, did it make you nervous to be behind someone like that? Because to us now he's such an icon. But what was his reputation at that time?

DH: He was very pleasant. I mean I didn't know Charlie Parker really, I didn't hang out with him. I didn't participate in any of the legendary all night sessions. I certainly didn't get high with him. But when I, the couple of times I played with him, and there is also one set at Birdland as I remember when Bud Powell didn't show up, he was just very pleasant and workmanlike, and quite agreeable.

MR: Great. Can you tell us about working in the modern day era these days, what it takes to keep working and maybe some of the film work you've done with Woody Allen and so forth? Has that been a pleasant experience? Something you like to do?

DH: Well I found that film music writing demands just about everything I've ever known, not just one aspect or another aspect, but such a job requires just about everything I know, because I do my own orchestration. And the films I've done with Woody have been one way of writing, and I did a bunch of other things too. They're all different, they all require a different approach, and they all require a cooperative way of creating the music, that is to say you have to be on the same wavelength as the director and the scene and the mathematics of the film, the timings, and of course, what it is you're trying to do. And I should also say and the budget. Sometimes you might think that it would sound great with a hundred violins, and you have a budget for about twelve pieces. So all of those things have to come into it. It's demanding and again it's like, as I said before, it's delayed gratification. You may not enjoy dealing with all the other personalities as it's happening, and all of the other considerations, but sooner or later it's worth it, except if they cut the music. If they cut the music that you've done, then it's rather disappointing. So you console yourself with recordings anyhow, and if you're lucky you can put all those things that weren't in the film into the cast album.

MR: Oh yeah. You just did "Sugar Babies" not that long ago.

DH: Well it's been a while back.

MR: It's been a while now?

DH: "Sugar Babies" was the only Broadway show I've orchestrated. It ran for quite a few years and they tell me it's still running now in dinner theaters and bus and truck stops and that kind of thing. By now, whatever I orchestrated is long gone. It's been cut down to a combo.

MR: Well I was wondering what's your feeling on some of the things that are happening in the music business today? Nowadays when you go to see a musical, often times in the pit there's two electric keyboards and maybe three other players. Is this something—

DH: Well you know at its best synthesized music can be very useful if you have those two synthesizers as part of the 25-man minimum in New York pit orchestras, they can be very helpful. They can make everything sound much bigger. But on the other hand, as you suggest, you can see musicals in other places than on Broadway, in which it's down to one man operating a whole gang of equipment, or maybe one man and a couple of other players. It think that's a pity. I think we lost something. A lot of people I think kid themselves about synthesized music. What we really have had happen is that people have learned to like the music of synthesizers, not that the music of synthesizers have reproduced an orchestra perfectly, because they don't. But many people like the sound of the synthesizers. Even some musicians prefer certain things you can get from a synthesizer than what you can get from a full string section. This is an interesting change.

MR: I've been told that at certain other festivals you've told some stories about some of the things that you've done during your career that make for an interesting tale. Do you have some things in your career that you maybe wouldn't want to do again?

DH: You are talking about a talk I gave last year when Don Miller honored me as their Musician of the Year. And I prepared a tape which I call "Sins of my Youth" which had a lot of very odd stuff on it.

MR: Do you want to share some of that?

DH: And you're right I wouldn't want to do it again, but I'm very happy to have done it, playing for a program called "Journey Through Ireland" as an organist. Well it was nice, it was nice music, but unlikely I would do it again anyway, playing for — a lot of the sins of my youth were as an organist I must confess, playing organ for a soap opera called "Front Page Farrell," for various quiz and game shows, especially "Beat the Clock." "Beat the Clock" was revived more than once. And in the late 60's and early 70's, it was revived first in New York and then we moved it up to Montreal. And we used to grind out those shows, five a day, and get two weeks of shows in two days. The whole thing was like producing sausages. And it was a funny, and not uncreative show from my point of view because I was expected to make up little sorts of rhythmic music behind the stunts that the contestants would be required to do. The stunts involved bouncing balls and balancing hoops and racing from here to there with hazards, and all kinds of funny stuff. It was essentially like playing silent movie piano.

MR: Have you ever done that?

DH: I have done that. I'm much too young to have played that era, but since then I have occasionally done it. Not too long ago I played on a Mighty Wurlitzer organ in Seattle at the Paramount Theater, playing for I guess it was a 1923 film by Harold Lloyd called "The Freshman." That's hard work. That's an hour and ten minutes, in that case, of playing and trying to know what you're going to do, and working the controls of the

organ and also craning your head up like that trying to watch the film at the same time. And people who did it in those days would do like four, five or six of those a day, forever.

MR: Do you have any stories that you could tell us about perhaps some gigs you've done with Joe Williams?

DH: Well, Joe, first of all I think that Joe is the greatest jazz singer there ever was. And I think his sense of time is just about as good as any great drummer in the business. And the funny thing was that one of the things that I did with Joe I didn't play on at all, but we were doing a show in tribute to Eubie Blake called "Eubie's Hundred Years" or something like that. It was on the occasion of his hundredth birthday. It was a show on public television out of Washington. Joe was one of the guests and part of the job, of my job as musical director, was locating music, old Eubie Blake music obviously. And in Eubie's files in his old brownstone house in Brooklyn, among a lot of other music, we found something called "I'd Give a Dollar for a Dime" with lyrics by Andy Razaf. It turned out to be a very nice, even plaintive song and very period in a tender sense because it's been a long time since anybody needed a dime for a jukebox. And Joe loved the song. But as I say, I didn't accompany him on it on the show, Frank Owens did. I was busy doing other things. It was one of the nicest moments on the show. Since then I have played that song with Joe on one or another occasion. He's just a very nice man in addition to his great talent. A nice gentleman.

MR: Let's suppose you could put together a dream band and go on a dream tour. Would it be too hard to pick people ...

DH: It would. That is why I prefer to play solo piano because I lose a great many of these complications.

MR: Yeah. Have you ever been a band leader per se? Like I know you have been on T.V.

DH: Yeah, you are talking about in the sense of going around the country.

MR: You had the repertory group?

DH: The closest I got to being a traditional on-the-road band leader was when I was directing the group which was then called "The New York Jazz Repertory Company" and we went to Russia, the Soviet Union that is, it wasn't just Russia. And this was in 1975 and it was a remarkable experience. We did our Louis Armstrong show, which we had done previously in Carnegie Hall. In Moscow, Novorossiysk, which is way the heck over North of India, Alma Ata, which is in the south now, and Kazakhstan, all these places which are coming into the news now unfortunately, and one or two other spots. And we toured in buses or on maybe once or twice on a Russian plane. And it was an amazing introduction to the hazards and hardships of being a leader of a big band, doing that in Russia.

MR: If you can do it there, you'd probably be able to do it anywhere, right?

DH: Well one of the problems was vodka, we'll say no more. And another was the fact that, although we were treated beautifully and everybody loved the music, ironically in far greater numbers than that concert drew or could draw even now in the U.S., we did run into some hazards of the Communist system. One time a bus couldn't leave at a certain point because a towel was missing. Somebody had stolen state property. You have to be very tricky, but you were in a situation where the government owns the towels. That literally happened. And then there were other cases where those people were under such a yoke at the time. There were jazz fans and we all wanted to be as friendly as we could to them, and I remember there was a guy who was the head of the jazz club in Yaroslavl, which is a city north of Moscow. We wanted to give him some records. It wasn't legal for him to accept records from us. We met in the park and we slipped them to him. Without saying a word, we put them from underneath our coat to underneath his coat, and he walked away as fast as he could. It was a moment out of classic espionage and that's exactly what happened. That kind of thing was a kind of normal style of living for them, and it just amazed us.

MR: Interesting. You live in Florida now?

DH: Now I do.

MR: Do you notice a difference, I assume you've worked on both coasts, and do you still like working in New York City or the west coast, or is it by choice that you're not in those areas anymore?

DH: Well I've never been really a west coast musician although I have done some film work there and occasional appearances. I'm still a New York musician fundamentally. I really couldn't make a comparison, and wouldn't do that question justice.

MR: Suppose we had some budding college musicians watching you right now and instructors sometimes give them lists of people to listen to. If you had to pick two or three, and they are aspiring jazz musicians —

DH: Well would you say they're aspiring jazz pianists?

MR: Yeah.

DH: Okay. Well then they ought to hear the greatest jazz pianist, who is Art Tatum. I would say they have to hear Art Tatum, they have to hear Oscar Peterson of course, and they have to hear Bill Evans, and they have to hear older stuff too: James P. Johnson, Teddy Wilson, that would be enough to start with. And that's of course in addition to what I imagine such people would already be interested in, I assume that they would know all about Chick Corea and Herbie Hancock and people more recent even than those two. But I'm saying of the music of the past, which I think is very important in order to play the present correctly.

MR: As a jazz musician through the years, what was your take on what was happening in the real popular field. When Elvis came on the scene and all that, today's jazz musician looks at the things, you know the rap is happening and Madonna and that kind of thing. Back then did you have an interest in that kind of music that was coming along, I mean —

DH: We all played it. We were all doing record dates that were trying to copy Elvis Presley and all the other, well I don't know is Elvis Presley rock 'n roll? I guess.

MR: He was for a while. And Chuck Berry and those guys.

DH: We all — studio musicians were expected to play everything and I found that I could fit into that kind of stuff because I knew how to play boogie woogie and blues piano from my big brother's record collection. I played a lot of stuff for Atlantic Records — Jerry Wexler and —

MR: What kind of people did you play behind?

DH: Ivory Joe, what's his name, Ivory Joe Hunter; Ruth Brown, whom I'm working with now; Lavern Baker; The Coasters; The Drifters maybe — no The Drifters; I remember that terrible record "White Christmas" that was so popular.

MR: Did you play on that?

DH: I did. But we did all that stuff. And if you asked me what we thought of it, we always — we said to each other can you imagine we said to each other, in twenty years, this was in 1955 or so, in twenty years people will be saying to each other, "listen darling, they're playing our song." And you know that's exactly what happened. All of that funny music that we laughed at became classic in rock. And go figure it out.

MR: Well people, even musicians who've never done studio work may not realize that you don't have to like everything you play on in a studio. It's not possible.

DH: No, no. What you have to like is being able to play it well.

MR: Correctly, yeah.

DH: And you do your best no matter what it is.

MR: It's interesting when you listen to some of the early like Chuck Berry records is you hear Chuck playing in this new rock 'n roll style and half the rhythm section is still playing swing music. So there's this real figuring out of what's happening here and it's very historical.

DH: You hear that in early bebop — "Shaw-nuff" you hear Dizzy and Bird playing bebop and the rhythm section is, if I remember right, Cozy Cole and Slam Stewart and Clyde Hart and they're playing swing, the same thing.

MR: Yeah, great.

DH: But at that time the music changed, you know. And for a long time older kind of pop music kind of coexisted and then gradually rock 'n roll won out altogether. Things were very different. It wasn't just abstract notions of style and aesthetics, it was the fact that

the economics were different, that there were staff orchestras where you could be working for a pretty decent weekly salary as a staff musician. Those don't exist anymore. There were staff orchestras in California — the film studios had their own orchestras — MGM for example. And live music was everywhere. There were always live bands playing or at least pianists or least organists or at least something playing everywhere you looked. This was very different from now, when most music you hear is synthesized or prerecorded.

MR: I have to tell you that today the solo you played on, was it "Crazy Rhythm" I'm still trying to figure out what you were doing in your left hand while you were — it almost sounded like you were thinking of J.S. Bach. Do you consciously think of —

DH: I've been trying to get a contrapuntal way of playing going and it's coming along.

MR: It seemed to work that time. Anything that you'd like to offer yourself that we haven't hit on today?

DH: No, you've really touched all the bases as far as — I thank you. I didn't realize that — I thank you for being so well informed.

MR: Well it's been a real pleasure to speak with you and Mr. Hyman has to go back to work shortly, so we're going to end this, and thanks a lot.

DH: Thank you.